I entered the Spouter-Inn and, after much pondering and throwing open the little window, I made out the smoke-dark painting: a half-foundered ship and an exasperated whale springing upon her three masts.

The house was full; I asked for a room and agreed to share. I never liked to sleep two in a bed.

Hain’t no objections to sharing a harpooneer’s blanket?


I chose the bench; the planing and the bitter draughts defeated me.
I shan’t sleep with him. I’ll try the bench.
Wait—I’ll make ye snug enough.

Does he always keep such late hours?

He went out a peddling—unless maybe he can't sell his head.

Peddling his head around town?

That's precisely it. The market's overstocked.

With what?

With heads, to be sure.

'Balmed New Zealand heads—he's sold all on 'em but one.

This account cleared up the otherwise unaccountable mystery.

Since it was Sunday, I took the prodigious bed and eyed his outlandish gear.

Come along—I'll give ye a glim in a jiffy.

Dozing at last, I saw the harpooneer come in with a New Zealand head, undress to tattooed squares, set a little wooden idol in the fireplace, burn shavings and biscuit, and sing out in strange gutturals.

He sprang into bed with the tomahawk-pipe. Peter Coffin said, "Don't be afraid; Queequeg won't harm a hair of your head."

Who-e debel you? You no speak-e—dam-me, I kill-e!

Landlord! For God's sake—Peter Coffin! Watch! Angels! save me!

He stashed the tomahawk-pipe; I turned in again and slept soundly.

Better sleep with a sober cannibal than a drunken Christian.

Tell him to stash that tomahawk-pipe. No smoking—I ain't insured.

I woke at daylight to find Queequeg's tattooed arm thrown over me, so blended with the patchwork counterpane that only its weight told me he was hugging me.

I wriggled to rouse him and found the tomahawk-pipe by his side.

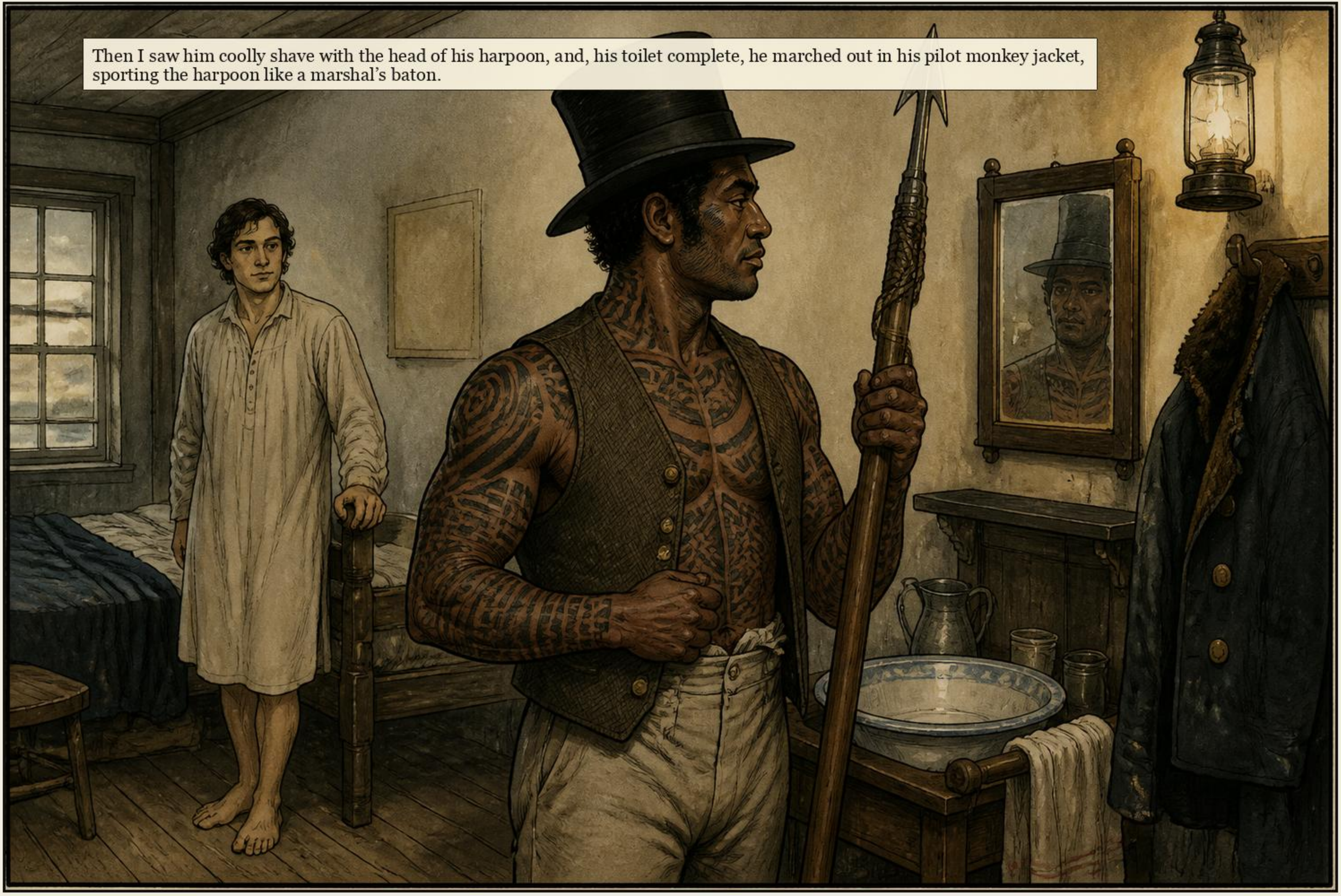
Queequeg! In the name of goodness—wake!

By much wriggling and loud expostulations I woke him; he drew back his arm, shook himself, and sat up staring, while I lay quiet and curious rather than afraid.

He made signs that he would dress first and then leave me to dress alone—a very civilized overture I accepted as I watched him.

I watched him begin at the top with his very tall beaver hat, hunt up his boots, crawl under the bed to pull them on, and limp creaking about the room.

Seeing there were no curtains and the house opposite looked in, I begged him to hasten into his pantaloons, whereupon he complied and washed only his chest, arms, and hands.


Then I saw him coolly shave with the head of his harpoon, and, his toilet complete, he marched out in his pilot monkey jacket, sporting the harpoon like a marshal's baton.